

The Complete Financial Guide for Young Couples

dren will be sure to let you know if you're not true to your word, and well they should. If you don't really mean it, don't say it.

(5) *Teach your children "sharing" principles from God's Word.* One thing I encourage you to avoid is the "quarter-in-the-plate" syndrome. Many Christian parents fall into that trap. There they are in church, the offering plate is coming around, so they give their children a quarter to drop in. That means absolutely nothing to most of them. They didn't earn the money, it didn't cost them anything, so giving becomes a religious ritual. I would encourage you to avoid that. It's best for your children to give only if it costs them something.

Help your children get involved with the needs of people. With most children what works best is to have them invest directly in the lives of other people, particularly the poor. Once they see that giving is God's way of sharing a surplus where others have a lack, it will become real to them. I know children who have supported orphans for several years, and they still get letters from those they were helping. Now they're grown and many have their own families. This helps children understand the purpose as well as the principle of giving. It isn't just dropping money in a plate. It's being involved in the lives of other people. Once a child is committed to that concept, nobody has to force him to give.

If you must force your children to give, somewhere along the way they'll get big enough to stop. If they give because of God's conviction and His Word, nobody will ever talk them out of it. I have met four- and five-year-old children who were committed to giving funds they had earned and felt it a privilege to do so. Some were able to give only a dime or a quarter, but they gave to meet the needs of another. A quarter isn't much in America, but in Mexico it will buy a day's food. As Paul said, "At this present time your abundance being a supply for their want, that their abundance also may become a supply for your want, that there may be equality" (2 Corinthians 8:14).

(6) *Teach your children to save.* Proverbs 21:20 says,